

The Household Codes in Their World

Ephesians and Colossians address wives, husbands, children, and slaves in a form Aristotle would have recognized. The form is familiar. The content keeps breaking it.

THE TRADITION

Aristotle Wrote the Outline

Four centuries before Paul, Aristotle opened his *Politics* with the household. The city is made of households, he argued, and the household is made of three relationships, master and slave, husband and wife, father and child. Managing these well was a recognized subject, household management, and it produced a long shelf of Greek and Roman writing. The pattern was consistent. The free adult male stands at the center. The other parties exist in relation to him, and the discussion is addressed to him, about how he should rule them.

Aristotle was explicit about the reasoning. The slave, he wrote, has no deliberative faculty at all, the woman has it but without authority, the child has it in immature form. Rule was therefore natural, not negotiated.

This tradition was still standard furniture in the first century. Philosophers, moralists, and Jewish writers like Philo and Josephus all produced versions of it. So when Ephesians 5 and 6 and Colossians 3 and 4 take up wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters, in that paired order, no ancient reader was surprised by the topic. The topic was as common as parenting advice is now.

THE FORM

What the New Testament Shares With It

We should be honest about the overlap. The household codes in Ephesians and Colossians work with the same three pairs Aristotle named. They assume the basic structure of the ancient household rather than abolishing it. Wives are told to submit to their husbands. Children are told to obey their parents. Slaves are told to obey their masters. First Peter runs a similar pattern for a suffering church under suspicion.

This is the part that embarrasses modern readers, and the embarrassment has produced bad history in two directions. Some conclude the apostles were simply men of their time, baptizing the social order as they found it. Others read the texts as if they dropped from heaven with no first-century address at all, timeless

regulations with no context worth knowing.

The better path is to set the codes beside their contemporaries and read closely. Form tells you what a text is doing in its world. Difference tells you what it is doing to its world. The form here is conventional. The differences are not small, and they all lean the same direction.

THE BREAK

Where They Break From It

Start with who gets spoken to. Aristotle addressed the male head of the house. The New Testament codes address everyone. Wives, children, and slaves are spoken to directly, as moral agents capable of hearing and choosing, members of the congregation where the letter was read aloud. In the standard tradition, a slave was a tool to be managed. In Colossians, a slave is a person who serves the Lord Christ and will receive an inheritance. The grammar itself is a quiet revolution.

Then the obligations run both ways. Husbands are not told to rule. They are told to love their wives as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her, an instruction with a cross in it. Fathers are told not to provoke or embitter their children. Masters are told to treat slaves justly and fairly, because they too have a Master in heaven, and with him there is no partiality. No partiality means the social ladder does not exist where it matters most.

And Ephesians sets the whole code under one strange heading. Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ. The ancient world knew how to order a household. It did not know how to begin with mutual submission.

THE TEST CASE

Philemon, the Letter That Strains the Category

The shortest proof is a personal letter. Paul writes to Philemon, a slave owner, about Onesimus, a slave who has become a Christian under Paul's ministry. Paul holds real authority and says so, then refuses to use it. He will not command. He appeals on the basis of love, and he asks Philemon to receive Onesimus back no longer as a slave but more than a slave, a beloved brother, and to welcome him as he would welcome Paul himself.

Notice what Paul does not do. He does not call for the abolition of slavery across the empire, a demand no first-century letter could enforce and no Roman authority would tolerate. Notice what he does. He makes the categories of master and slave unworkable between two men who must now call each other brother and share one table at one Lord's supper.

It took the church centuries too long to follow that thread to its end, and Christians on the wrong side of that history quoted the household codes while ignoring this letter. That failure belongs to us. It is in our

family record. The text was patient with us longer than it should have needed to be.

SOBER READING

Against Reading Backward

Two anachronisms are on offer, and both flatten the texts. The first reads the codes as if Paul were a modern egalitarian in disguise, embarrassed by submission language he did not really mean. That will not survive contact with the Greek. The second reads them as a timeless charter for hierarchy, as if the point of Ephesians 5 were to settle who is in charge. That will not survive contact with the first century, where the codes were heard as restraint on the powerful, not reinforcement of them. A husband commanded to die for his wife has not been handed a privilege.

Scholars like Lynn Cohick and Craig Keener have done the patient work of placing these texts among their neighbors, and the result is consistent. The codes meet their world where it stands and bend it toward the cross.

We study the background for one reason. To hear what the text said before deciding what we wish it had said. Context is not a tool for escaping hard verses, and it is not a weapon for winning household arguments. It is a way of standing under the text with the people who heard it first. They heard their names called. So do we.

KEY TEXTS

Ephesians 5:21-6:9

Colossians 3:18-4:1

Philemon 15-16

SOURCES

Women in the World of the Earliest Christians — Lynn H. Cohick

Paul, Women and Wives — Craig S. Keener

Backgrounds of Early Christianity — Everett Ferguson

Honor, Patronage, Kinship and Purity — David A. deSilva